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CURRENT ISSUES

On the Ontological Status of Autism: the ‘Double Empathy Problem’.

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(Received 8th June 2012; final version received xxxxxxxx)

Abstract

In recent decades there has been much debate over the ontological status of autism and other neurological ‘disorders’, diagnosed by behavioural indicators, and theorised primarily within the field of cognitive neuroscience and psychological paradigms. Such cognitive-behavioural discourses abstain from acknowledging the universal issue of relationality and interaction in the formation of a contested and constantly reconstructed social reality, produced through the agency of its ‘actors’ (Garfinkel, 1967). The nature of these contested interactions will be explored in this current issues piece through the use of the term the ‘double empathy problem’ (Milton 2011a), and how such a rendition produces a critique of autism being defined as a deficit in ‘theory of mind’, re-framing such issues as a question of reciprocity and mutuality. In keeping with other autistic self-advocates, this piece will refer to ‘autistic people’, and ‘those who identify as on the autism spectrum’, rather than ‘people with autism’ (Sinclair, 1993).

Introduction

Socrates: ...Can you point out any compelling rhetorical reason why he should have put his arguments together in the order that he has?

Phaedrus: You do me too much honour if you suppose that I am capable of divining his motives so exactly. (Plato, 1973: 78).

In recent decades there has been much debate over the ontological status of autism and other neurological ‘disorders’, diagnosed by behavioural indicators, and theorised primarily within the field of cognitive neuroscience and psychological paradigms. The triad of dominant theories that include: theory of mind deficit, executive dysfunction, and weak central

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coherence theory, as well as behavioural diagnosis and behavioural psychological intervention paradigms; all position autism as a neurological disorder, a pathological deviance from expected functional stages of development. This approach when applied to the

当前议题

论孤独谱系的本体论地位： ‘双向同理心问题’

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(收稿日期：8th 2012年6月；终稿收稿日期： xxxxxxxx)

摘要

近几十年来，关于孤独谱系及其他神经性‘障碍’（通过行为指标诊断，主要在认知神经科学和心理学范式领域内进行理论化）的本体论地位存在诸多争论。此类认知-行为话语回避承认关系性与互动性这一普遍问题，即在形成一种充满争议且不断重构的社会现实中的作用，这种现实是由其‘行动者’的能动性所生产的（*Garfinkel, 1967*）。本文将通过使用‘双向同理心问题’（*Milton 2011a*）这一术语，探讨这些争议性互动的本质，并分析此种表述如何对将孤独谱系定义为‘心智理论’缺陷的观点提出批判，从而将此类问题重新框架为互惠性与相互性的问题。与其他孤独谱系自我倡导者保持一致，本文将使用‘孤独谱系群体’和‘认同为处于孤独谱系上的人’，而非‘患有孤独谱系的人’（*Sinclair, 1993*）。

引言

苏格拉底：……你能指出任何有力的修辞理由，说明他为何必须按照他所采用的顺序来组织他的论点吗？

斐德罗：如果你认为我能如此精确地洞察他的动机，那真是对我过于抬举了。（柏拉图，1973: 78）。

近几十年来，关于孤独谱系及其他神经性‘障碍’的本体论地位存在诸多争论，这些障碍通过行为指标诊断，并主要在认知神经科学和心理学范式领域进行理论化。主导理论的三要素包括：心智理论缺陷、执行功能障碍以及弱中央

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连贯性理论，以及 行为诊断和行为心理干预范式； 都将孤独谱系定位为一种神经发育障碍，一种偏离预期功能发展阶段的病理偏差。当这种方法应用于

education of those diagnosed becomes a ‘treatment program’ of modifying the ‘autistic person’ as ‘best one can’ to fit in with the mainstream culture of society. Such views are informed by research that champions the use of the randomised controlled trial, yet discounts the subjective experiences of those who identify as being on the autism spectrum themselves as worthy of rigorous academic study. Such cognitive-behavioural discourses abstain from acknowledging the universal issue of relationality and interaction in the formation of a contested and constantly reconstructed social reality, produced through the agency of its ‘actors’. The nature of these contested interactions will be explored in this current issues piece through the use of the term the ‘double empathy problem’ (Milton 2011a), and how such a rendition produces a critique of autism being defined as a deficit in ‘theory of mind’ and social interaction, re-framing such issues as a question of reciprocity and mutuality.

Assumptions of social relationality

The inability to ‘read’ the subtext of a social situation is often deemed to be a major feature of those diagnosed as being on the autism spectrum, yet it is suggested here that social subtext is never fully given as a set of *a priori* circumstances, but is actively constructed by social agents engaged in material and mental production. There is a tendency in the application of positivist methodologies in cognitive psychology and science to incorrectly assume that there is a set of definable social norms and rules that exist for people to follow. This ideology is also supported more explicitly by functionalist sociologists. This is not the philosophy propounded by those of a phenomenological or ethnomethodological persuasion however. The ‘theory of mind’ and ‘empathy’ so lauded in normative psychological models of human interaction, refers to the ability a ‘neuro-typical’ (NT) individual has to assume understandings of the mental states and motives of other people. When such ‘empathy’ is applied toward an ‘autistic person’ however, it is often wildly inaccurate in its measure. Such attempts are often felt as invasive, imposing and threatening by an ‘autistic person’, especially when protestations to the contrary are ignored by the NT doing the ‘empathising’.

The ‘double empathy problem’: A disjuncture in reciprocity between two differently disposed social actors which becomes more marked the wider the disjuncture in dispositional perceptions of the lifeworld - perceived as a breach in the 'natural attitude' of what constitutes 'social reality' for ‘neuro-typical’ people and yet an everyday and often traumatic experience for ‘autistic people’.

被诊断者的教育时，就变成了一项‘治疗方案’，旨在‘尽最大可能’地改造‘孤独谱系人士’，以使其适应社会的主流文化。这些观点源于推崇使用随机对照试验的研究，却贬低了那些自认为身处孤独谱系者的主观体验，认为其不值得进行严谨的学术研究。此类认知行为论述回避承认关系性和互动性在形成一种充满争议且不断被重构的社会现实中的普遍性问题，而这种现实是通过其‘行动者’的能动性产生的。这些充满争议的互动的本质，将在本篇时事评论中通过使用‘双向同理心问题’（Milton 2011a）这一术语进行探讨，并分析这种诠释如何对将孤独谱系定义为‘心智理论’和社会互动缺陷的观点提出批判，从而将此类问题重新框定为互惠性与相互性的问题。

社会关系性的假设

无法“解读”社交情境的潜台词，常被视为被诊断为孤独谱系人士的主要特征，但本文认为，社交潜台词从来不是作为一套先验情境被完整给定的，而是由参与物质与精神生产的社会行动者主动建构的。在认知心理学与科学中应用实证主义方法论时，存在一种倾向，即错误地假设存在一套可定义的社会规范与规则供人们遵循。这种意识形态也得到了功能主义社会学家更明确的支持。然而，这并非现象学或常人方法学取向者所宣扬的哲学。在人类互动的规范性心理学模型中备受推崇的“心智理论”与“共情”，指的是一个“神经典型”（NT）个体所具有的、能够推测他人心理状态与动机的能力。然而，当这种“共情”被施加于一位“孤独谱系人士”时，其衡量往往极不准确。此类尝试常被“孤独谱系人士”感受为侵入性、强制性与威胁性的，尤其是当相反的抗议被进行“共情”的NT个体忽视时。

T‘双向同理心问题’：指两位不同倾向的社会行动者之间在互惠性上出现断裂，这种断裂随着双方对生活世界的倾向性感知差异越大而越显著——它被视作对‘神经典型’人群所认为的‘社会现实’之‘自然态度’的违背，而对‘孤独谱系群体’而言，却是一种日常且常具创伤性的体验。

To expand on the above definition, the ‘double empathy problem’ refers to a breach in the ‘natural attitude’ that occurs between people of different dispositional outlooks and personal conceptual understandings when attempts are made to communicate meaning. In a sense it is a 'double problem' as both people experience it, and so it is not a singular problem located in any one person. Rather, it is based in the social interaction between two differently disposed social actors, the disjuncture being more severe for the non-autistic disposition as it is experienced as unusual, while for the ‘autistic person’ it is a common experience (Milton, 2011b). The ‘empathy’ problem being a ‘two-way street’ has been mentioned by both ‘autistic writers’ (Sinclair, 1993) and NT writers alike (Hacking, 2009), yet despite such protestations, the ‘lack of theory of mind’ myth persists.

The stigma of being ‘othered’ and the normalisation agenda

To be defined as abnormal is potentially to be seen as 'pathological' in some way and to be socially stigmatised, shunned, and sanctioned. Then if there is a breakdown in interaction, or indeed a failed attempt to impose upon or align toward expressions of meaning, than a person who sees their interactions as 'normal' and 'correct' can denigrate those who act or are perceived of as ‘different’ (Tajfel and Turner, 1979). If one can apply a label on the ‘other’ locating the problem in them, it also resolves the applier of the label’s ‘natural attitude’ of responsibility in their own perceptions and the breach is healed perceptually, but not for the person who has been 'othered' (Said, 1978).

Internalised oppression and psycho-emotional disablement

The imposition of one’s views upon another and the subsequent internalisation of this view can be seen to be a form of internalised oppression, where the negative connotations of the normative model of pathological difference becomes a self-fulfilling prophecy (Becker, 1963), leading to a self-imposed psycho-emotional disablement (Reeve, 2011). For those who resist such self-identifications and attempts to normalise, however ‘well intentioned’, are experienced as an 'invasion' of the ‘autistic’ ‘lifeworld’ by people wanting to modify one’s behaviour to suit their purposes and not one’s own (Milton and Lm, 2012).

Autism and knowledge production

Although compared to many categorisations of disability, autism has attained a great deal more public attention and that one could say that the label has become a fetishised commodity and even a global industry (Mallet, 2011), yet it is an industry that silences the

为扩展上述定义，‘双向同理心问题’指的是当不同倾向性视角和个人概念理解的人们试图沟通意义时，发生在他们之间的‘自然态度’断裂。某种意义上它是一个‘双重问题’，因为双方都体验到它，因此并非仅存在于任何单一个人身上的单一问题。相反，它根植于两位不同倾向的社会行动者之间的社会互动中，这种断裂对非孤独谱系倾向者而言更为严重，因为它被体验为异常，而对‘孤独谱系人士’来说则是常见经历（Milton, 2011b）。‘同理心’问题作为一条‘双向通道’，已被‘孤独谱系作者’（Sinclair, 1993）和NT作者（Hacking, 2009）共同提及，但尽管有这些异议，‘缺乏心智理论’的谬论依然持续存在。

被‘他者化’的污名与常态化议程

被定义为异常，可能意味着在某种程度上被视为‘病态的’，并遭受社会污名化、回避和制裁。那么，如果互动中出现破裂，或者确实试图强加或调整意义表达的尝试失败，那么一个认为自己的互动是‘正常’和‘正确’的人就可以贬低那些行为或被感知为‘不同’的人（Tajfel和Turner, 1979）。如果一个人能够对‘他者’施加标签，将问题定位在他们身上，这也解决了标签施加者在其自身感知中的‘自然态度’责任，破裂在感知层面得以愈合，但对于被‘他者化’的人来说并非如此（Said, 1978）。

内化的压迫与心理情感性失能

将自己的观点强加于他人，以及随后对此观点的内化，可以被视为一种内化的压迫形式，其中病理差异规范性模型的负面含义成为一种自我实现的预言（Becker, 1963），导致自我施加的心理情感性失能（Reeve, 2011）。对于那些抵制此类自我认同和试图常态化的人，无论其意图多么‘良好’，都被体验为对‘自闭症’‘生活世界’的‘入侵’，人们想要修改一个人的行为以适应他们的目的，而非本人的目的（Milton和Lm, 2012）。

孤独谱系与知识生产

尽管与许多其他障碍分类相比，孤独谱系获得了更多的公众关注，甚至可以说这个标签已成为一种被迷恋的商品乃至全球性产业（Mallet, 2011），但它却是一个压制

autistic voice from any participation, other than in the form of a tokenistic gesture. Therefore, far from owning the means of mental production about one’s own culture, the ‘autistic individual’ becomes the 'product' of the industry, the 'thing' that is 'intervened' with. 'Services' are provided for the carer's of ‘autistic people’ with often little attention given to the needs of the ‘autistic person’ as they perceive them to be. Autism is not just an ‘invisible disability’ to many in terms of a behavioural definition, the ‘autistic voice’ is made ‘invisible’ within the current culture of how knowledge produced about ‘autistic people’ often excludes empowered ‘autistic advocates’ from such processes.

Implications for service providers

There is a spectrum in theory and practice more generally regarding service provision for ‘autistic people’, between at one end those adhering to techniques of behavioural modification, so that children are socialised into what are deemed appropriate behaviours of socially functional future roles. At the other extreme of this spectrum is an ethos of interactive mutuality concerned with the empowerment of individuals and communities, and where dominance and imposition of authority is seen as ‘dysfunctional’. Expressions of these extremes could be said to be found more frequently in discourses regarding best educational practice for ‘autistic people’, ranging from the efforts of the Lovaas model of Applied Behavioural Analysis, through to child-focused and democratic educational ideological preferences. These narratives and practices can be said to be embedded within the wider discursive debate that exists between the medical and social models of disability as played out in the field of autism. It is the view of this author that there is an increasing complacency around the idea that lead professionals and practitioners have a good understanding of what 'good autism practice' entails, for me this is an ongoing imperfect process of interaction and should never be seen as a given.

Conclusion

The lack of 'social insight' seen to be manifested in the actions of ‘autistic people’ is both biologically and socially derived, and yet is also historically and culturally situated in discourse. The experience of a lack of realisation or the lack of insight is a very common one in social interactions of many varieties however, and leads to the ‘double empathy problem’ between differently disposed social actors. Such divergences of perception are inevitable to a greater or lesser extent. So it is true that autistic people often lack insight about NT perceptions and culture, yet it is equally the case that NT people lack insight into the minds

孤独谱系声音参与任何事务的产业，除了象征性的姿态之外。因此，远非掌握关于自身文化的精神生产手段，'孤独谱系个体'反而成为该产业的产品'，成为被'干预'的'物件'。为'孤独谱系群体'的照料者提供的'服务'，往往很少关注'孤独谱系人士'自身感知的需求。对于许多人而言，孤独谱系不仅是一种行为定义上的'隐形障碍'，在当前的文化中，关于'孤独谱系群体'的知识生产过程常常排斥拥有话语权的'孤独谱系倡导者'，使得'孤独谱系声音'变得'隐形'。

对服务提供者的启示

在为‘孤独谱系群体’提供服务方面，理论和实践中普遍存在一个光谱，一端是那些坚持行为矫正技术的人，目的是让儿童社会化，融入被认为适合未来社会功能性角色的行为。在这个光谱的另一极端，是一种互动相互性的理念，关注个体和社区的赋权，其中权威的主导和强制被视为‘功能失调’。这些极端观点的表达可以说更频繁地出现在关于‘孤独谱系群体’最佳教育实践的论述中，范围从应用行为分析的Lovaas模型的努力，到以儿童为中心和民主的教育意识形态偏好。可以说，这些叙事和实践嵌入在更广泛的、存在于残疾的医学模式与社会模式之间的论述辩论中，这一辩论在孤独谱系领域展开。本文作者认为，对于主导专业人士和实践者已充分理解‘良好孤独谱系实践’内涵这一观点，存在日益增长的盲目自满；在我看来，这是一个持续且不完美的互动过程，绝不应被视为理所当然。

结论

在‘孤独谱系人士’行为中表现出的‘社会洞察力’缺失，既有生物学根源也有社会性成因，同时也在话语层面被置于特定的历史与文化情境中。然而，缺乏觉察或缺乏洞察力的体验在多种社会互动中其实非常普遍，并导致了不同倾向的社会行动者之间的‘双向同理心问题’。这种感知上的分歧或多或少是不可避免的。因此，孤独谱系人士确实常常对NT人士的感知与文化缺乏洞察，但同样地，NT人士也缺乏对

and culture of ‘autistic people’, or that they may lack social insight in other social situations due to an easily repaired natural attitude, and the aligning tendencies of their peers. One could say that many autistic people have indeed gained a greater level of insight into NT society and mores than vice versa, perhaps due to the need to survive and potentially thrive in a NT culture. Conversely, the NT person has no pertinent personal requirement to understand the mind of the ‘autistic person’ unless closely related socially in some way.

In analysing the interactions that ‘autistic people’ have with the wider population, it is easy to problematise the definition of autism as a ‘social deficit’ located within an individual’s mind. Differences in neurology may well produce differences in sociality, but not a ‘social deficit’ as compared to an idealised normative view of social reality. Such definitions may help to signpost disability support services, but they are no way of defining autism in any kind of holistic sense.

Socrates: But suppose the words used are ‘just’ and ‘good’. Don’t we then go each his own way, and find ourselves in disagreement with ourselves as well as with each other?

Phaedrus: Undoubtedly. (Plato, 1973: 77).

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‘孤独谱系人士’的内心与文化的洞察，或者他们可能因一种易于修复的自然态度及其同辈的趋同倾向，而在其他社会情境中缺乏社会洞察力。可以说，许多孤独谱系人士对NT社会及其习俗的洞察水平确实比NT人士对孤独谱系群体的了解更高，这或许是为了在NT文化中生存乃至发展下去的需要。相反地，除非存在某种密切的社会关联，否则NT人士并没有迫切的个人需求去理解‘孤独谱系人士’的内心世界。

在分析‘孤独谱系群体’与更广泛人群的互动时，很容易将孤独谱系定义为个体心智中的‘社交缺陷’这一问题化。神经系统的差异确实可能导致社交方式的差异，但相较于理想化的规范性社会现实观，这并非一种‘社交缺陷’。此类定义或许有助于标示残疾支持服务，但它们绝非以任何整体性方式定义孤独谱系的方法。

苏格拉底：但假设使用的词语是‘公正’和‘善良’。我们难道不是各自走自己的路，结果不仅与他人意见相左，也与自己内心产生分歧吗？

斐德罗：毫无疑问。（柏拉图，1973: 77）。

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